

Biomass Energy and AI — Community Reforestation in Mitsue Village



A 25-Year Initiative in Forest Regeneration, Distributed Renewable Energy, and Community-Owned Digital Infrastructure in Rural Japan

Location: Mitsue Village, Nara Prefecture **Start:** April 2026 **Duration:** 25 years **Current stage:** Phase 0 (entity setup) **Project Lead:** Rob Oudendijk (YR-Design / Safecast)

Overview

A non-profit initiative that repurposes aging sugi (Japanese cedar) plantations, idle village facilities (including the former Sugano Elementary School), and the surrounding forest landscape into an integrated model of rural regeneration. Three activities are unified under a single operating structure:

1. **Native-species reforestation** — Working with private landowners, the Forestry Agency, and local forestry operators to gradually convert aging sugi plantations to native broadleaf species (konara oak, kunugi oak, chestnut, etc.). A 25-year ecological timeline that restores food sources for deer, wild boar, and bears — reducing wildlife damage while recovering biodiversity.
2. **Locally sourced biomass CHP energy** — Thinned wood fuels 24-hour baseload power and heat, complemented by solar, EV charging, and community backup power.
3. **Community-owned small-scale data center** — An edge compute facility powered by local renewable energy.

The power generated is not only for local use: it has two commercial outlets — sale under Japan's FIT/FIP scheme and supply to the AI data center. This revenue is a sustained funding source for the reforestation program, making the project self-sustaining.

Alignment with Mitsue Village's official plan

This project is not a new proposal but an implementation vehicle — a public-private operating structure to carry out the plan the village itself formulated and committed to in its "Maximizing Renewable Energy Introduction Plan," published January 2025.

Why this overlaps with Sakoda-san's research

We believe your knowledge of reforestation and seedling/seed research applies directly to this project's reforestation program — converting aging sugi plantations to native broadleaf species — and would very much welcome the opportunity to draw on your expertise.

Current progress (Phase 0)

Meetings with the village vice-mayor and local forestry groups; drafting of founding charter and implementation plan; advisory board formation (including Ray Ozzie); CHP advisor engaged (SynTech Japan); collaboration agreement with more trees; entity-structure discussions with Mizuho Securities.

Contact Rob Oudendijk / rob@yr-design.biz / mitsue.it